



The Case for a Later Bell

Grade 8 • North Carolina • Reading

RI.8.6

Determine an author's point of view or purpose in an informational or persuasive text, and analyze how the author acknowledges and responds to conflicting evidence or opposing viewpoints. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 8 · North Carolina · Reading; RI.8.6 — Determine an author's point of view or purpose in a text and analyze how the author acknowledges and responds to conflicting evidence or viewpoints.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

An author's purpose is what they want the text to accomplish (to inform, persuade, or both); their point of view is the position they hold on the topic. Strong persuasive writing at grade 8 often directly acknowledges opposing evidence or viewpoints rather than ignoring them, then explains why the author's position still holds despite that opposing evidence.

Model 1 — An article arguing for a new bike lane states: "Some worry a bike lane will slow car traffic. Traffic studies from three similar cities found delays of under sixty seconds during peak hours." What is the author doing here?

The author is acknowledging a specific opposing concern (slower traffic) and then directly responding to it with evidence, rather than ignoring the concern or pretending it does not exist.

Model 2 — If that same article never mentioned traffic concerns at all, only listing reasons bike lanes are beneficial, how would that change a reader's trust in the argument?

A reader might trust the argument less, since ignoring an obvious counterargument can make a persuasive text seem one-sided or unaware of real objections, rather than confident enough to address them directly.



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What explicit claim does paragraph 1 make about adolescent sleep cycles?

2. What is the author's stated purpose in this article, and where is it most clearly expressed?



The Case for a Later Bell (Part 1)

1. Our school day begins at 7:25 a.m., which means most students wake by 6:00 to be ready in time. Sleep researchers have found that adolescent brains naturally shift toward later sleep and wake cycles during the teenage years, a biological change, not a matter of discipline or bedtime habits. Starting school this early, for this age group, works against biology rather than with it.
2. The evidence for a later start time is substantial. A 2019 study across eight districts that delayed start times by at least thirty minutes found an 11 percent drop in reported daytime sleepiness among students and a measurable improvement in first-period attendance. Districts that shifted to a 8:30 a.m. or later start also reported fewer car accidents among teen drivers, likely connected to reduced drowsy driving during early morning commutes.
3. I recognize this proposal is not free of real complications, and I want to address the two objections I hear most often directly, rather than pretend they do not exist.



The Case for a Later Bell (Part 2)

4. The first objection is athletics and after-school activities. Coaches and parents worry that a later school day pushes practices and games later into the evening, cutting into time for homework, family dinners, and sleep — the very thing this proposal is meant to protect. This is a legitimate concern. Districts that delayed start times successfully did not simply add thirty minutes to the end of the day; several shifted athletic practice earlier by making corresponding adjustments to bus schedules and shortening the school day's midday block, keeping the overall school-plus-activities day roughly the same length.

5. The second objection is transportation cost. Many districts run two staggered bus routes, with elementary schools starting later than secondary schools specifically to reuse the same buses and drivers. Reversing that order, so secondary schools start later instead, could require additional buses or drivers, a real cost that smaller districts in particular have cited as a barrier. Some districts have addressed this by staggering elementary and secondary start times only slightly differently rather than reversing them entirely, reducing but not eliminating the added cost.

6. Neither objection is imaginary, and neither has been fully solved everywhere a later start time has been proposed. But in districts that found workable adjustments to both athletics scheduling and transportation costs, the sleep and safety benefits held, suggesting the objections are practical obstacles to plan around, not reasons the underlying case for a later start time is wrong.



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says Quote or closely paraphrase the text.	It Means Explain the evidence in your own words.	And So State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. What explicit statistic does paragraph 2 provide about the 2019 study's findings on daytime sleepiness?

2. What does the author explicitly state their intention is in paragraph 3?

3. What is the first objection the author acknowledges in paragraph 4, and who does the author say raises it?

4. How does the author respond to the athletics objection in paragraph 4, rather than simply dismissing it?

Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. What is the second objection the author acknowledges in paragraph 5, and what is its specific cause?

2. How does the author's response to the transportation objection in paragraph 5 differ in confidence from the response to the athletics objection in paragraph 4?

3. What explicit statement does the author make in paragraph 6 about whether either objection has been fully solved?

Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. Why might the author choose to admit that the objections are not fully solved everywhere, rather than claiming they have been completely resolved?

2. How does the phrase "practical obstacles to plan around, not reasons the underlying case... is wrong" in paragraph 6 summarize the author's overall response to both objections?

3. Identify the author's point of view on later school start times, and cite one piece of evidence used to support it.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. Explain how the structure of this article (claim, then evidence, then two objections and responses) helps achieve the author's persuasive purpose.

5. A reader claims the author only mentions objections to make the article seem fair, without really taking them seriously. Using evidence from paragraphs 4 through 6, evaluate whether this claim is accurate.

6. If the article had ended after paragraph 2, without addressing any objections, how might that change a skeptical reader's response to the author's point of view?



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. What explicit detail does paragraph 2 give about the connection between later start times and teen driver safety?

2. Why does the author include the driver-safety statistic in paragraph 2 in addition to the sleepiness statistic? What does it add to the argument?

Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. What transition does paragraph 3 provide between the evidence-focused paragraphs (1-2) and the objection-focused paragraphs (4-5)?

2. Compare the phrase "a real cost that smaller districts in particular have cited as a barrier" (paragraph 5) to the phrase "this is a legitimate concern" (paragraph 4). What do both phrases reveal about the author's approach to opposing viewpoints?

Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. Explain how the author's point of view in this article differs from simply presenting "both sides equally." Use evidence to support your answer.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. Adolescent brains naturally shift toward later sleep and wake cycles during the teenage years, a biological change rather than a matter of discipline or habit.
2. The author's purpose is to persuade readers to support a later school start time; it is most clearly expressed in the title and in paragraph 1's claim that early start times "work against biology rather than with it."
3. An 11 percent drop in reported daytime sleepiness among students in districts that delayed start times by at least thirty minutes.
4. To directly address the two objections heard most often, rather than pretend they do not exist.
5. The objection that a later school day pushes athletics and after-school activities later into the evening; the author says coaches and parents raise this concern.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. The author cites specific evidence that some districts adjusted bus schedules and shortened the school day's midday block, keeping the overall school-plus-activities day roughly the same length, directly addressing the concern with a practical solution rather than denying it matters.

7. The objection of increased transportation cost, caused by many districts reusing the same buses and drivers for staggered elementary and secondary routes, which reversing would disrupt.

8. The transportation response is more measured, admitting some districts have only "reduced but not eliminated the added cost," while the athletics response describes districts that kept the day's overall length "roughly the same," suggesting a more complete solution was found for that objection.

9. The author explicitly states that neither objection is imaginary and neither has been fully solved everywhere a later start time has been proposed.

10. Admitting the objections are not fully solved makes the author appear honest and credible rather than overselling the proposal, which can make the overall argument more persuasive to a skeptical reader.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. It reframes both objections as solvable logistical problems rather than fundamental flaws in the argument, allowing the author to acknowledge real difficulties while still maintaining their original point of view.

12. The author supports later school start times; one piece of supporting evidence is the 2019 study's finding of an 11 percent drop in daytime sleepiness across eight districts.

13. This structure builds the case with evidence first, establishing credibility, and then proactively addresses likely objections, which can make skeptical readers feel their concerns are being taken seriously rather than ignored, strengthening the overall persuasive effect.

14. This claim is not well supported; paragraphs 4 and 5 include specific evidence of how some districts practically addressed each objection, and paragraph 6 explicitly admits neither objection is fully solved everywhere, showing the author engages with the objections substantively rather than dismissing them for appearance only.

15. A skeptical reader might find the argument less convincing or one-sided, since real logistical concerns like athletics and transportation would go unaddressed, potentially making the proposal seem impractical or naive about real-world implementation challenges.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. Districts that shifted to an 8:30 a.m. or later start reported fewer car accidents among teen drivers, likely connected to reduced drowsy driving during early morning commutes.

17. It broadens the argument beyond comfort or academic performance to a concrete public-safety concern, giving the author's point of view an additional, more urgent kind of supporting evidence.

18. Paragraph 3 explicitly announces the shift, stating the author will address the two most common objections directly rather than pretend they do not exist, signaling a change in the article's structure and purpose.

19. Both phrases show the author validating the opposing viewpoint as genuine and reasonable rather than exaggerated or dismissed, which is consistent with the article's overall strategy of acknowledging objections honestly before responding to them.

20. The author clearly favors later start times throughout, presenting supporting evidence first and using most of the article to argue for the position; the objections are acknowledged and responded to, but the article does not treat the case for and against later start times as equally weighted, since it consistently returns to evidence supporting the author's original point of view.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

Official alignment source • accessed September 18, 2026

RI.8.6 — Determine an author's point of view or purpose in a text and analyze how the author acknowledges and responds to conflicting evidence or viewpoints.. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the standard.

NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 8: <https://www.thecorestandards.org/ELA-Literacy/RI/8/6/>

Original passage(s), questions, and answer explanations. No official released-test items or branded curriculum reproduced.

Print US Letter at actual size. Keep the answer key separate from student pages. Single-teacher classroom or LMS use; no resale or redistribution of complete files.